people’s minds. As many yatris would undoubtedly attest, I can recount multiple instances of bystanders proactively coming up to us to give us fruits, to hug and bless us. Often we didn’t understand the language, even though what they wanted to say was abundantly clear. I remember early on in Kerala, since some of us were sleeping along with the civil society contingent, we had to make our own arrangements (at least for the first couple of weeks, after which the Congress party began making arrangements for civil society). After walking over 22 kilometres, we had to first locate the primary school we were to sleep in and then wash our clothes for the next day. By the time we began hunting for food, it was past 10.30 p.m. and nearly everything was shut. Exhausted and conscious that we had to be back on the road before 6 a.m., we went into the first open restaurant that we chanced upon. While we were waiting for the food, we were excitedly sharing anecdotes of what we had experienced earlier in the day. Suddenly the manager came by to enquire if we were Bharat yatris. His eyes lit up when we replied in the affirmative, and he asked us to stay for as long as we wanted (even though the cashier had just told us we would have to order takeout since they were closing in fifteen minutes). He asked if he could join us and eagerly soaked in our conversation like a schoolboy. Ten minutes into the conversation, someone brought us food and drinks that we hadn’t ordered. The manager sheepishly interjected to say that it was his treat, and refused to entertain our protests. He went on to say his father was a district-level leader in the Communist Party of India and wanted to join the Yatra (along with many from the Left parties), but couldn’t due to the unfortunate temporary tensions between the two parties because of a leader’s unmindful remarks. He went on to say that while he himself could not join the Yatra, helping us was his contribution to this second Dandi Yatra. He warmly hugged me before I left and gave me a small packet of tapioca and banana chips for the journey ahead. It was during this incident that I first realized that the Yatra was much more than just political.

Transcending the norms of politics, Bharat Jodo had a profound impact on all of us. Looking back at when I first began the Yatra, I recall mentally preparing myself to engage with the masses. I recall feeling unsure—